



Longest Open-era final: At 5 hours and 53 minutes, the 2012 AO summit clash between Djokovic and Nadal pushed every possible limit of endurance.

and pronounced himself “the big favourite obviously”. For Nadal, the most devastating loss of his career — falling to Federer in the 2007 Wimbledon final — would inspire his most momentous triumph. After that defeat, he reportedly sat on the shower floor for 30 minutes, crying in despair and self-recrimination.

In 2008, the two protagonists brought out the spectacular in each other with attacks and ripostes that screamed “Anything you can do, I can do better!”. Spectators chanted “Come on, Roger” and “Come on, Rafa” throughout changeovers during the dramatic denouement. Serving for the championship, the swashbuckling Spaniard struck three clever and bold winners, including his only serve-and-volley, followed by a Federer return error, to achieve his life’s work, sacrifice, and dream.

For 28 years, cognoscenti ranked the unforgettable Borg-McEnroe 1980 Wimbledon final as the sport’s most brilliant and riveting match. But after the Federer-Nadal extravaganza of almost superhuman tennis, which broke the record for being the longest final in Wimbledon history, John McEnroe — the very McEnroe of that famed 1980 match — couldn’t restrain his enthusiasm: “This was a magnificent, unbelievable, truly memorable match. This has to be the greatest match we’ve ever seen.”

🎾 **Djokovic def. Nadal 5-7, 6-4, 6-2, 6-7, 7-5 — 2012 Australian Open final**

For sustained brilliance and suspenseful twists, the 2012 Australian Open final ranks as an all-time classic, second only to the Nadal-Federer 2008 Wimbledon final.

Nadal led 4-2, 30-15 on his serve in the fifth set but missed an easy backhand passing shot by inches.

SEA OF RECORDS

- Has won four different tournaments 10 or more times — French Open (14), Barcelona Open (12), Monte Carlo Masters (11), and Italian Open (10).

- First player to win multiple Majors in three different decades — six in the 2000s, 13 in the 2010s, and three in the 2020s.

- Holds the longest winning streak on a single surface among male players, with 81 consecutive victories on clay.

- Owns the men’s record for the most clay-court titles, an astonishing 63, far ahead of Guillermo Vilas with 49.